The Limits and Possibilities of Alignment (November 1962–November 1963)

In the immediate aftermath of the Sino-Indian war, the Chinese threat loomed large for India. On a trip just after the war, presidential envoy Averell Harriman detected a sense in India that "Red China was determined to destroy India's independence and way of life." He noted that everyone he met "unanimously spoke of the emergency in long-range terms."[2] Indeed, Galbraith observed that if there was a "principal gain" of the war for the US, it was that India wholeheartedly acknowledged the Chinese threat.[3] Defense Minister Yashwantrao Balwantrao (Y. B.) Chavan feared another attack.[4] Nehru, believing China wanted to humiliate India, was also concerned that the ceasefire might be just a temporary tactic. To make matters worse, China seemed to be winning the propaganda battle with a number of African and Asian countries.[5]

Externally and internally, India seemed vulnerable, having suffered setbacks in the security and economic spheres. Along with the defeat—which Ramachandra Guha has called Nehru's "most consequential failure"—there were food and foreign exchange shortages and the third five-year plan was faltering.[6] The government was concerned that this economic strain would affect its ability to strengthen India's defense capabilities. Furthermore, it might also make the government politically vulnerable to the charge of not delivering the goods and India internally vulnerable to subversion and communism. This pessimistic atmosphere stood in sharp contrast to that a few months before, when Chester Bowles had commented on an "overriding impression … of tremendously increased Indian self-confidence, both in [the] economic field and vis-à-vis China."[7]

American officials, too, were worried about Indian vulnerability, with questions about what its potential failure would mean for US security. They considered China an even greater challenge. They now found an Indian *willingness* to contain China. But the shocking speed and scale of its defeat generated questions and disillusionment—even among advocates like Robert Komer and John Kenneth Galbraith—about Indian *ability* to contain China. Such doubts had preceded the war, but they reached a new level.

Outside the administration, commentators compared India's "indescribable poverty" and "will-less Government" unfavorably with "the